Marketing & Enrollment: Facilitator Guide

Business Academy Group Learning · Marketing & Enrollment · April 2027

Session at a glance

In 60 minutes, providers learn how families find and choose child care, strengthen their online presence and tours, and set up a simple waitlist so open slots fill faster. Spring timing helps programs plan for summer and fall turnover.

Item	Detail
Month	April 2027
Audience	Business Academy providers, center-based and home-based
Length	60 minutes
Format	[In person / virtual]
Materials	Sample program description, tour checklist, sample waitlist form, printed Tips and Tricks sheet and Provider Handout
Ask providers to bring	A phone or laptop to check their online listings, plus current enrollment and openings

Learning goals

By the end, each provider can:

1. Calculate their fill rate and the cost of an empty slot.
2. Describe what makes their program different in one or two sentences.
3. Improve one online listing or marketing channel.
4. Set up or clean up a waitlist and follow-up routine.

Agenda

Time	Segment
0:00 – 0:05	Welcome and opener: “How did your last family find you?”
0:05 – 0:15	Why marketing matters: the cost of an empty slot
0:15 – 0:30	Your message, online presence, tours, and waitlists
0:30 – 0:45	Activity: Write your 30-second program pitch
0:45 – 0:55	Implementation: your 30-day plan and one commitment
0:55 – 1:00	Takeaways and wrap-up

Why marketing and enrollment matter

Opener, "How did your last family find you?": Tally answers on a flip chart: word of mouth, online search, social media, referral agency, sign, other. Most rooms see word of mouth and online search at the top.

Talking points:

- **Empty slots are lost income.** Use the Budgeting Tool to show what one empty slot costs over a year.
- **Families shop before they call.** Many look online first; an outdated listing can lose a family before you ever talk.
- **Your current families are your best marketers.** Happy families refer friends.
- **Enrollment is a process.** Inquiry, tour, enrollment, and staying enrolled each need attention.
- **A waitlist is a safety net.** It turns a sudden opening into a quick phone call instead of weeks of empty space.

Core content: filling and keeping spots

The enrollment path

Stage	What families need	What you can do
Finding you	Accurate, easy-to-find information	Update online listings, ask for reviews, keep a simple sign or social page
First contact	A quick, friendly response	Return calls and messages within one business day
Tour	To feel their child will be safe and happy	Use a tour checklist; show your routine and introduce teachers
Enrolling	Clear next steps and costs	Give a packet with tuition, policies, and start date
Staying	Good communication and trust	Regular updates, quick problem-solving, a check-in after the first month

Know your numbers

- **Fill rate:** enrolled children divided by licensed spaces.
- **Cost of an empty slot:** weekly tuition times the number of weeks it stays empty.
- **Tour-to-enroll rate:** how many tours turn into enrollments.

Your program message

Help providers answer three questions in plain words: Who do you serve? What makes your program special? What should a family do next? This becomes a 30-second pitch, a listing description, and the opening of every tour.

If the program accepts subsidy, remind providers to say so clearly in their listings; it helps families who need it find them.

Implementation: your 30-day plan

Each provider leaves with one commitment and a 4-week plan; the Business Specialist checks progress at the next coaching session. Progress here also counts toward the pilot goal of at least one new or improved business practice per provider.

Week	Action	Done when
Week 1	Calculate your fill rate and the yearly cost of one empty slot.	Both numbers are written down
Week 2	Search for your program online as a parent would; update every listing you find.	Listings are current
Week 3	Write your 30-second pitch and a tour checklist.	Pitch and checklist are ready
Week 4	Start or clean up your waitlist; contact everyone on it.	Waitlist is current

Tie-in to coaching

At the next individual coaching session, the Business Specialist will:

- ☐ Review fill rate and the cost of an empty slot
- ☐ Look at updated listings and the program pitch
- ☐ Check the waitlist and follow-up routine
- ☐ Note any business practice change in the provider's progress record

Commitment card

Have providers fill this in before they leave and keep a copy:

- My fill rate is: _____
- One empty slot costs me per year: _____
- The listing or channel I will update: _____
- I'll follow up on inquiries within: _____

Key takeaways

Close the session by reading these aloud; they also appear on the Provider Handout.

1. **Empty slots cost money.** Know your fill rate and what an opening costs you.
2. **Be easy to find.** Keep online listings accurate and current.
3. **Respond fast.** Families often choose the program that calls back first.
4. **Make tours count.** Show what makes your program special, and give clear next steps.
5. **Keep a waitlist.** It fills openings faster and protects your income.

Activities and discussion

Activity: Write your 30-second pitch (15 minutes)

Providers write three sentences: who they serve, what makes them special, and what a family should do next. They practice with a partner, who gives one compliment and one suggestion. Volunteers share with the group.

Discussion questions

- What do families say they love most about your program?
- What questions do families ask most on tours?
- Where have you seen the best results from marketing?
- Why have families left your program in the past?

Peer Connections prompt (April)

“Filling open slots: share one strategy.” Each provider shares one thing that helped them fill an opening quickly, such as a referral incentive, a social media post, or a waitlist call.

Handouts for this session

Walk through the **Marketing & Enrollment Tips and Tricks** sheet during the content segment, and give out the **Marketing & Enrollment Provider Handout** at the end.